

Democratic Congress would not cut defense spending

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【メール原文】

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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If Democrats win unified control of Congress (60% odds) in the midterm elections, they will likely slow, but not reverse, the rapid growth in defense spending of recent years.

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The need to address weaknesses in the defense industrial base and replenish depleted interceptor stockpiles will create bipartisan support for higher spending, likely leading to defense spending increasing by 3.5% to 5% in nominal terms next year.

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Democrats would deprioritize the White House’s marquee programs, such as the Golden Dome, and would emphasize process improvements at the Pentagon, while Republican and industry lobbies will retain influence even as private capital expands its role in defense.

Unified Democratic Congress would slow, not reduce, defense spending. Topline defense spending has increased every year in nominal terms since Congress lifted the Budget Control Act spending caps in 2015. That pattern will likely continue under the next Congress, regardless of which party controls the House and Senate. Historically, split control of Congress has produced defense increases closer to those under unified Republican control than under unified Democratic control. Though the topline is approaching \$1 trillion, a deeply controversial level for many progressives, a few more Democratic Socialists in Congress would not materially change the Democratic caucus vote count on defense. Lawmakers would still need to address current weaknesses in the defense industrial base and depleted interceptor stockpiles during the fiscal year 2028 cycle, which would create bipartisan support for higher, targeted spending. As a result, defense spending would likely rise between 3.5% to 5% in nominal terms from current levels, keeping it between 3 and 3.5% of GDP.

Democrats would deprioritize Trump’s marquee programs. Democrats have questioned President Donald Trump’s use of reconciliation for national defense and will likely structure the fiscal year 2028 budget as a single base proposal. If Congress fails to pass reconciliation funding in the fiscal year 2027 cycle, key priorities such as shipbuilding and interceptor production would remain unfunded. In that case, lawmakers would probably cut Trump’s signature projects first to create room in the base budget.

Some initiatives, such as Golden Dome, serve important purposes but have been criticized for unclear objectives and weak evidence that spending will produce results. Lawmakers would likely target those programs for reductions to better align funding with their stated goals. Other initiatives, such as the Golden Fleet, have almost no political support on Capitol Hill and may be eliminated in the fiscal year 2028 legislative cycle. Even so, higher spending on defense industrial base priorities, including munitions production and critical minerals, would likely offset or exceed those cuts.

Democrats would also emphasize process improvements at the Pentagon. Democrats would first push for full Pentagon briefings after months of limited communication about the war in Iran. They would also probably scrutinize Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's acquisition reform efforts. So far, Hegseth's Pentagon has favored a "go fast and break things" approach to procurement, using tools such as Other Transaction Authority contracts, Commercial Solutions Opportunities, and debt and equity stakes in private companies to expand defense production quickly. Industry has welcomed those efforts, but many Democrats have criticized their opaque structure and the appearance of noncompetitive bidding that favors firms backed by the Trump family. Democrats may support the broader goal of speeding procurement, but they would likely seek to reform or restrict those mechanisms through the next National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) —and potentially subject them to congressional corruption inquiries—along with other flawed processes such as discriminatory military promotions. Even so, some narrower organizational reforms, including portfolio-level acquisition changes, are likely to remain in place.

Republicans and industry lobbies would retain influence as private capital expands its role in defense. Even if Democrats control Congress, Republicans would retain leverage to advance GOP priorities at the margins. Democratic committee chairs would strongly shape the amendment process for the NDAA, but majority control would not prevent conservative riders from reaching the final bill. In the current legislative cycle, defense industry lobbyists will likely target both sides of the aisle to push for spending increases and a strong government demand signal after the current continuing resolution. However, Democrats are unlikely to reverse the ongoing decline in basic research funding because they face many competing priorities. That trade-off would have minimal impact on industry because private capital is playing a larger role in financing basic research and prototyping for new market entrants. Private credit institutions and industry lobbyists, therefore, share an interest in promoting spending that supports entrants in areas such as mission autonomy, energetics, and mineral refinement. On balance, these overlapping interests will likely drive more investment toward procurement, which would help keep overall topline spending at or above current levels.

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